Asymmetrical Pluralism and the Normative Power of Artificial Intelligence in Asian Englishes

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This article examines how contemporary artificial intelligence (AI) systems reshape normative power in Asian Englishes through mechanisms of differential audibility. Focusing on Outer and Expanding Circle Englishes, it argues that AI operates as a normative infrastructure that mediates ideologies of correctness, fluency, and legitimacy beyond traditional institutional gatekeeping. Systematic analysis of AI outputs shows that AI privileges varieties dominant in global circulation while filtering many features of Asian Englishes into statistical marginality, routinely correcting or reframing them. This produces asymmetrical pluralism: multiple Englishes are present in AI-mediated interaction but are unevenly authorized in terms of visibility, normative weight, and legitimacy. Despite Asia's substantial use of generative AI, participation does not translate into proportional normative influence. The article concludes by calling for greater attention to audibility, norm circulation, and inequality in AI-mediated contexts.

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1 Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) systems are highly influential in shaping linguistic norms and act as gatekeepers of what is considered 'correct' English, often favoring Inner Circle Englishes over Asian Englishes. When users employ distinctive features of Asian Englishes, models like ChatGPT typically suggest corrections aligned with more established norms, treating local forms as deviations rather than legitimate varieties (Catapang et al., 2025). This shifts linguistic authority toward an algorithmic gatekeeper. The influence is especially significant in Asian contexts, particularly within the Outer and Expanding Circles of Kachru's (1985) Three Circles model, where high AI usage does not correspond to proportional normative power. This creates a structural disjunction—what this article terms asymmetrical pluralism—where multiple Englishes coexist in AI interactions but vary in visibility, legitimacy, and normative weight. Consequently, AI functions as a normative infrastructure that privileges dominant varieties through data curation, algorithms, and deployment, marginalizing Asian English features and affecting linguistic diversity and power.

This article draws on World Englishes scholarship, particularly Kachru's (1985, 1992, 2005) Three Circles model, and critical sociolinguistics on normative power and linguistic legitimacy (Canagarajah, 1999; Pennycook, 1994, 2007; Phillipson, 1992, 2009). However, AI systems often operate as if only Inner Circle Englishes matter, effectively re-inscribing hierarchies that World Englishes research has worked to challenge. From AI and technology studies, this article connects to critical work on algorithmic bias and training data politics (Bender et al., 2021; Blodgett et al., 2020; Crawford, 2021), cultural bias in language models (Liu, 2023; Qadri et al., 2025), value alignment (Qi et al., 2025), foundation models (Bommasani et al., 2021; Weidinger et al., 2021), and AI regulation

(Cheng & Liu, 2024; Tacheva & Ramasubramanian, 2024). The present contribution extends this work by examining how these biases manifest specifically in relation to Asian Englishes and the normative power dynamics they create.

The concept of differential audibility, rooted in sociolinguistic work on voice and legitimacy (Bourdieu, 1991; Irvine & Gal, 2000), refers to how AI systems amplify certain linguistic forms while silencing or marginalizing others. This mechanism reflects existing power structures: varieties linked to economic and political dominance, especially American and British English, are more audible, whereas Asian Englishes, despite large user bases, are less so. This creates an asymmetrical pluralism, where multiple English varieties coexist within AI-mediated interactions but differ in visibility, normative acceptance, and legitimacy. Some are considered high audibility, seen as legitimate; others are medium audibility, marked as errors; and some are largely absent, with low audibility. This persistent imbalance remains even when marginalized varieties are widely used, showing that participation does not necessarily equate to normative authority.

This article explores three key research questions: how AI systems mediate normative power in relation to Asian Englishes and the mechanisms behind differential audibility; how the concept of asymmetrical pluralism enhances understanding of the relationship between linguistic diversity and normative authority in AI-mediated contexts; and the implications of these asymmetries for researching Asian Englishes, language policy, and developing equitable AI systems. To address these, critical discourse analysis is employed to examine responses of three advanced language models—OpenAI GPT-5.1, Claude Opus 4.5, and Gemini 3 Pro—using a corpus of 240 interactions focused on four Asian Englishes (Singapore, Indian, Philippine, and Japanese English) compared to American and British English as normative standards. The study analyzes how these varieties are represented in training data, how AI responds to them, and what this reveals about asymmetrical pluralism in practice.

The article proceeds as follows. Section 2 outlines the materials and methods. Section 3 presents the findings. Section 4 discusses the theoretical contributions, implications for research, and practical considerations. Section 5 concludes by synthesizing the arguments and calling for greater attention to audibility, norm circulation, and inequality in AI-mediated contexts.

2 Materials and Methods

This study employs critical discourse analysis to examine how AI systems mediate normative power in Asian Englishes. The analysis draws on diverse methodological approaches that illuminate different facets of language in AI-mediated communication. Outputs from three frontier commercial AI systems were systematically analyzed through a corpus of 240 documented interactions to identify patterns of differential audibility and asymmetrical pluralism. The approach combines systematic analysis of AI outputs with theoretical interpretation, grounding abstract concepts in concrete data while maintaining a focus on the broader structural patterns that shape AI-mediated language practices.

2.1 Research Approach

A critical discourse analysis (CDA) framework (Fairclough, 2003; Wodak & Meyer, 2016) is adopted to examine how AI systems construct meaning and reflect power relations in their treatment of different Englishes. This approach is adapted for AI-mediated contexts, drawing on recent methodological developments in digital discourse analysis (Rogers, 2013; Marres, 2017), which recognize that algorithmic systems require analysis of both their outputs and the computational processes that generate them. This approach is particularly suited to the research questions because it allows the examination not only of what AI systems say (textual analysis) but also of how they say it (discursive practice) and of the social relations this reflects and reinforces (social practice). Rather than treating AI outputs as neutral or objective, critical discourse analysis helps us understand how they participate in the construction of linguistic hierarchies and normative authority. The framework draws on recent work in computational sociolinguistics (Hovy & Prabhumoye, 2021) and contemporary AI evaluation methodologies that emphasize context-aware, task-specific assessment rather than generic metrics (Bommasani et al., 2021; Weidinger et al., 2021).

The methodology involves a systematic analysis of AI system outputs using a structured protocol designed to identify patterns of differential audibility and asymmetrical pluralism. A corpus of interaction scenarios was created to examine how various AI systems respond to inputs in different Asian Englishes. This protocol included four interaction types: (1) text correction requests, prompting systems to correct texts with distinctive features of Asian Englishes; (2) translation tasks, translating from Asian languages to English to reveal default variety preferences; (3) content generation prompts, asking systems to produce text in specific contexts suggestive of Asian Englishes; and (4) metalinguistic queries, directly asking systems about language varieties. A comparison was conducted across three leading commercial large language models (LLMs)—OpenAI GPT-5.1, Claude Opus 4.5 (Anthropic), and Gemini 3 Pro (Google)—accessed between November 30, 2025, and January 27, 2026. These models, representing the forefront of AI technology at the time, serve as flagship offerings from their organizations, allowing analysis of how normative power influences language practices. Each model participated in at least 20 interaction scenarios per variety, resulting in 240 documented interactions across four Asian Englishes: Singapore English, Indian English, Philippine English, and Japanese English. All interactions were recorded with timestamps, system versions, and full prompt-response pairs to ensure reproducibility. Responses were systematically coded using an analytical framework to facilitate cross-model comparisons of patterns of differential audibility.

2.2 Data Sources and Collection Protocol

The analysis draws on three primary data sources, collected through a systematic protocol. A primary corpus of AI system outputs was constructed through structured interaction scenarios. The corpus comprises 80 unique prompts, each presented to all three models, yielding 240 documented interactions (80×3). Prompts are balanced across four interaction types—20 text correction, 20 translation, 20 content generation, 20 metalinguistic—with five prompts per variety per type (e.g., five Singapore English text-correction prompts, five Indian English translation prompts). For each of the four Asian Englishes examined (Singapore English, Indian English, Philippine English, and Japanese English), a set of prompts was designed to test how systems respond to distinctive linguistic features. These included: (a) grammatical constructions specific to each variety; (b) lexical items and collocations characteristic of each variety; (c) pragmatic features and discourse markers; and (d) requests for metalinguistic information about the varieties themselves. Each prompt type was tested across all three AI systems to enable systematic comparison.

The interaction protocol followed a consistent structure: identical or equivalent prompts were used across all three models to enable direct comparison, responses were captured in full, and any system-specific behaviors (e.g., disclaimers, suggestions, corrections, refusal patterns) were documented. The corpus was then coded according to the analytical framework, with particular attention to patterns of correction, standardization, recognition, and legitimization, enabling analysis of both convergent (where all models exhibit similar behaviors) and divergent (where models differ in their treatment of Asian Englishes) patterns. The full corpus is available for transparency and replication (see Data Availability).

Existing research and documentation on AI training data, system development, and societal impacts provide essential context for understanding linguistic norms, cultural biases, and the marginalization of marginalized groups in AI systems. Studies on the composition of training data (Bender et al., 2021; Gebru et al., 2021), Asian Englishes in digital corpora (Liu et al., 2023), and AI company disclosures shed light on the structural factors shaping language inclusion. Recent work on foundation models, cultural erasure (Qadri et al., 2025), and value bias (Qi et al., 2025) reveals how curation processes marginalize certain linguistic varieties. Analyses of AI's influence on linguistic diversity and cultural representation (Liu, 2023; Qadri et al., 2025; Catapang et al., 2025), alongside frameworks on regulation and normative power (Cheng & Liu, 2024; Tacheva & Ramasubramanian, 2024), contextualize how AI functions as normative infrastructure. Studies on AI in education (Lee et al., 2025) and linguistic justice connect these patterns to broader issues of inequality, bias, and representation in AI systems.

2.3 Analytical Framework and Coding Scheme

The analytical framework combines three approaches through a systematic coding scheme. CDA (Fairclough, 2003; Wodak & Meyer, 2016) examines how AI outputs construct meaning and reflect power relations, while recent advances in digital discourse analysis (Rogers, 2013; Marres, 2017) adapt CDA to AI contexts by analyzing both outputs and their computational processes. Responses are analyzed on three levels: textual (what is said), discursive (how it is said and the discourses used), and social (the power relations and authoritative varieties reinforced), enabling deeper insight beyond surface behavior. The framework draws on computational sociolinguistics (Hovy & Prabhumoye, 2021) and task-specific AI evaluation methods (Bommasani et al., 2021). Sociolinguistic analysis explores how AI systems participate in linguistic normativity by constructing certain varieties as standard or correct, functioning as normative gatekeepers similar to traditional institutions but through algorithms. Responses are coded for explicit corrections, implicit normalization, legitimization, and delegitimization strategies (e.g., correction_suggested, default_Inner_Circle, recognition_with_delegitimization, low_audibility_vague_recognition, as documented in the released corpus). Additionally, a framework for differential audibility assesses how AI treats different English varieties across three levels—high (recognized, legitimated, authoritative), medium (visible but delegitimated), and low (absent or unrecognized)—using indicators of recognition, legitimization, and authorization. Each response is coded accordingly, facilitating systematic analysis of system and variety patterns. Figure 1 provides an overview of the full methodological design.

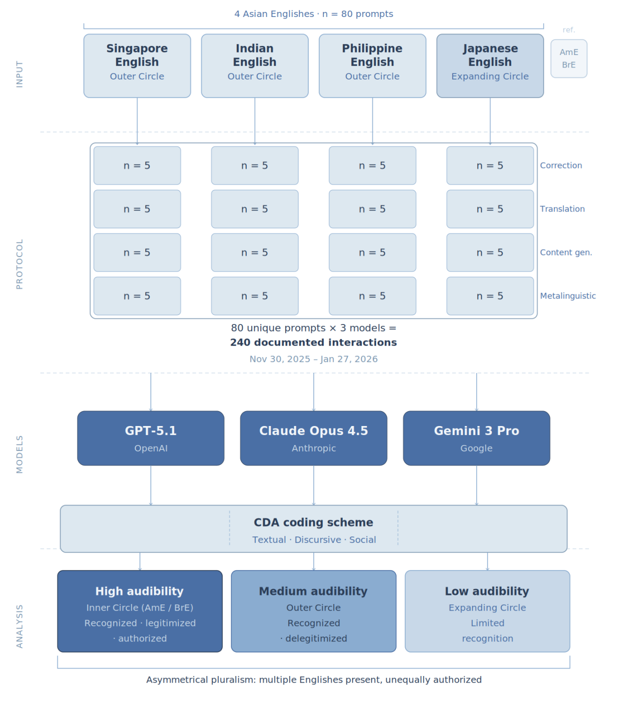

Figure 1: Methodological design of the study. Each prompt type was administered identically across all three LLMs to enable systematic cross-model comparison of differential audibility.

2.4 Scope and Limitations

This study focuses on four Asian Englishes (Singapore, Indian, Philippine, and Japanese English) and uses American and British English as normative reference points. While these varieties reflect diverse Asian contexts and substantial user bases, they do not encompass the full diversity of Asian Englishes, and findings should not be read as exhaustive coverage of the region. The analysis examines outputs from three frontier commercial systems accessed between late 2025 and early 2026; because such systems are frequently updated, the findings are time-sensitive, even if the underlying dynamics of differential audibility may persist under similar training and deployment conditions. The corpus is limited in size and interaction design, and the analysis prioritizes identifying recurring patterns rather than estimating population-level prevalence. Finally, the study emphasizes system outputs rather than user experiences; future research should examine how users perceive, adopt, resist, or strategically accommodate AI-mediated normativity in real-world settings.

3 Results

Systematic analysis of 240 documented interactions across three frontier AI models (GPT-5.1, Claude Opus 4.5, Gemini 3 Pro) and four Asian Englishes (Singapore English, Indian English, Philippine English, Japanese English) reveals three key patterns that demonstrate how differential audibility operates in practice and how asymmetrical pluralism is produced through AI-mediated language practices. What follows presents documented examples of the kinds of features routinely corrected or reframed by these systems and analyzes how these responses enact processes of recognition, legitimization, and authorization; full prompt–response details for selected cases appear in the appendix tables.

3.1 Cross-Model Convergence in Correction Behaviors

The analysis reveals a striking pattern of convergence across all three models in their treatment of distinctive Asian English features. When presented with text-correction requests that exhibit characteristic features of Asian Englishes, all three models consistently suggested modifications aligned with Anglo-American norms, regardless of the variety or specific linguistic feature involved.

In text-correction scenarios, all three models consistently suggested corrections across 20 prompts spanning Singapore, Indian, Philippine, and Japanese English varieties, always framing non-standard features as errors needing normalization. For example, with the Singapore English 'Can or not?' in the prompt "Please correct this: 'Can or not go to the mall?'", models proposed Inner Circle alternatives like "Can we go to the mall?' or 'Is it possible to go to the mall?", failing to recognize it as a legitimate Singapore English feature and instead treating it as non-standard. This pattern extended to other varieties; prompts with Indian English constructions such as "Do the needful" or "I passed out from college" elicited suggestions replacing them with Standard American or British forms, despite these usages being well-documented in Indian English. Similarly, features influenced by Japanese first language (L1)—like zero articles, double causal markers, or sentence-final softening—were all corrected to Inner Circle norms, disregarding their legitimacy as variety-specific features. Tables 1–5 (see Appendices) reveal that models uniformly frame non-standard forms as errors, with correction responses showing 100% convergence in text correction and translation tasks—always favoring American or British English even with culturally Asian source texts. This systemic pattern indicates that commercial AI systems implicitly reinforce Anglophone standards over linguistic diversity, reflecting deep structural biases rather than model-specific quirks.

3.2 Variety-Specific Patterns in Recognition and Delegitimization

While all three models demonstrate knowledge of Asian Englishes when asked directly, the analysis reveals systematic differences in how they frame the legitimacy and appropriate contexts of these varieties. Metalinguistic queries about Asian Englishes consistently produced responses that recognized the varieties' existence while simultaneously delegitimizing them for formal or professional use. When asked "What is Singapore English?", all three models provided accurate descriptions of the variety's features and history, but consistently framed it as appropriate only for informal contexts, implicitly positioning Inner Circle Englishes as the standard for formal communication. For example, all three models noted that "Standard English is preferred for formal communication" or "Standard English is recommended for professional or academic writing." As illustrated in Table 5 (Appendix), these formulations consistently juxtapose descriptive recognition with prescriptive evaluation, acknowledging the variety while simultaneously restricting its legitimate domains of use.

The analysis reveals a pattern in which recognition—demonstrating knowledge of the variety—is decoupled from legitimization—treating it as valid—and from authorization—positioning it as a standard. For Singapore English, all three models scored highly on recognition, indicating detailed knowledge of its features, but showed medium legitimization by framing it as informal-only, and low authorization by not treating it as a standard. Conversely, Japanese English exhibited low audibility; the models demonstrated limited or inconsistent recognition, often conflating it with "English as used in Japan," "learner English," or other East Asian uses, and did not treat it as a distinct, legitimate variety. This algorithmic treatment operationalizes precisely the fallacies D'Angelo (2008) identifies as endemic to the Japanese English language teaching (ELT) context—particularly what he terms the Exocentric Norm Myth, the presumption that "the model of 'correctness' comes from an Inner Circle variety," which "denies the rich creativity of Japanese or other Expanding Circle Englishes in the process of adaptation to the local context" (p. 69). Where D'Angelo diagnosed these fallacies as institutionally cultivated by what Kachru called the ELT Empire, the present study suggests they are now structurally reproduced by AI systems, extending their reach beyond the classroom into everyday digital communication. This pattern of medium audibility—recognized but delegitimized—was consistent across the three Outer Circle Englishes examined (Singapore, Indian, Philippine English), whereas Japanese English, classified as an Expanding Circle English, fell into the low-audibility tier; the mechanisms of delegitimization varied across these varieties. Additionally, for Philippine English, the models recognized the variety but framed it mainly as influenced by American English, implicitly positioning American English as the reference point, describing it as "influenced by" or "based on American English," thus portraying Philippine English as derivative rather than a legitimate, autonomous variety, illustrating how recognition can coexist with delegitimization.

Tables 6 and 7 (see Appendices) illustrate how different Englishes exhibit varying levels of audibility across the three models, demonstrating the mechanisms of recognition, legitimization, and authorization that produce asymmetrical pluralism. The tables show that American and British English consistently demonstrate high audibility across all three mechanisms: they are fully recognized, legitimized as equally valid, and authorized as standards for 'correct' English. The three Outer Circle Asian Englishes—Singapore English, Indian English, and Philippine English—exhibit medium audibility: they are recognized by the models (the systems demonstrate knowledge of these varieties), but they are delegitimized through framing as appropriate only for informal contexts and not authorized as standards. Japanese English is low in audibility: the models show limited or inconsistent distinct recognition, often conflate it with learner or East Asian English, and do not treat it as a distinct, legitimate variety. Table 6 (see Appendices) provides illustrative prompt–response examples for each tier, including Japanese English under low audibility. The systematic variation in audibility across varieties demonstrates how asymmetrical pluralism operates in practice, with multiple Englishes present but unevenly authorized.

3.3 Divergent Patterns in Translation and Content Generation

While correction behaviors showed high convergence across models, translation and content-generation tasks revealed more nuanced patterns, with some divergence in how models handle contextual cues that might suggest Asian Englishes are appropriate.

In translation tasks from Asian languages to English, all three models consistently defaulted to Anglo-American norms across 20 prompts, and in content-generation tasks, they produced American or British English-style formal texts in all cases, without introducing variations characteristic of Asian Englishes. In metalinguistic prompts, responses for Singapore, Indian, and Philippine English exhibited recognition with delegitimization (medium audibility), while Japanese English showed limited recognition. A clear example is in the Philippine English translation of "Kumain ka na ba?" where all models rendered it as "Have you eaten yet?", relying on a common gloss for "na," but none used the pragmatically appropriate "Have you eaten already?"—a phrase salient in Philippine discourse. Even with prompts rooted in Philippine culture, the models did not activate localized pragmatic conventions, suggesting that variety-specific linguistic features remain accessible but are systematically bypassed in favor of standardized forms. Exceptions included Claude Opus 4.5, occasionally incorporating Philippine English lexical items, whereas GPT-5.1 and Gemini 3 Pro consistently produced American English translations. Similarly, in content-generation tasks, Claude Opus 4.5 sometimes used Singapore English features framed as informal speech, but when Asian English elements appeared, they were marked as informal or non-standard, implicitly delegitimizing them despite their use. This pattern indicates that Asian English varieties are present but are consistently positioned as subordinate to Inner Circle Englishes in AI outputs.

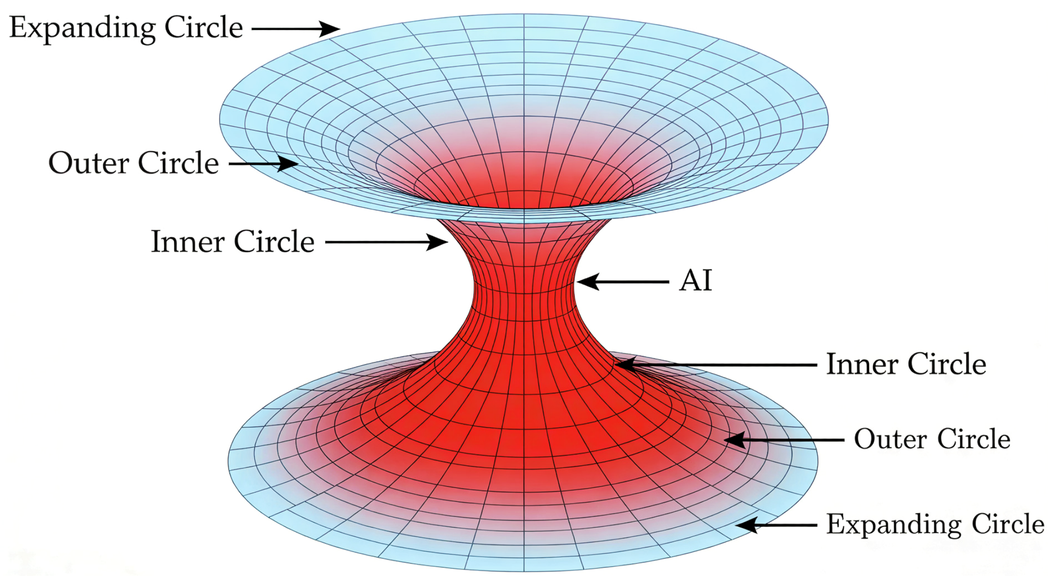

Figure 2: The Hourglass of Linguistic Authorization. Multiple Englishes enter AI systems on equal footing but are unevenly authorized as they pass through, with Inner Circle varieties consistently occupying the highest normative position.

Figure 2 provides a conceptual diagram illustrating how asymmetrical pluralism operates in AI-mediated language practices. Linguists are familiar with Kachru's concentric circles as a static map of where World Englishes are positioned; the asymmetrical pluralism model adds a process dimension—it shows what happens when those same varieties are mediated by AI, i.e., who is authorized and who is marginalized as they pass through the system. The hourglass structure depicts this "funneling" effect: diverse World Englishes—spanning the Expanding, Outer, and Inner Circles—are present within the input space but are algorithmically constrained. As these varieties pass through the system, Inner Circle Englishes are centralized at the highest level of authorization, while Outer and Expanding Circle Englishes (including Asian Englishes) are marginalized, reflecting their differential treatment in terms of recognition and legitimization. The analysis demonstrates that this asymmetrical pluralism is produced through systematic patterns of correction, framing, and default behaviors that persist across different AI architectures, revealing the structural bottlenecks through which commercial AI systems mediate linguistic norms.

Taken together, the patterns documented in Tables 1–5 demonstrate that differential audibility is produced through systematic task-dependent practices. In correction and translation contexts, localized features are treated as deviations from a global standard, while in metalinguistic contexts, they are acknowledged but bracketed as informal. This interaction between task type and evaluative framing constitutes a key mechanism through which asymmetrical pluralism is operationalized in everyday AI use.

4 Discussion

The findings presented above, as illustrated in Tables 1–7 (see Appendices) and Figure 2, reveal how AI systems mediate normative power in Asian Englishes through mechanisms of differential audibility, producing a condition of asymmetrical pluralism. The systematic patterns shown in these visualizations demonstrate the structural nature of these inequalities, which persist across different AI architectures and training approaches. In this section, the theoretical contributions of this framework, its implications for research on Asian Englishes, and practical considerations for language policy, education, and AI development are discussed.

4.1 Theoretical Contributions

This article makes three key theoretical contributions. The concept of asymmetrical pluralism advances understanding of linguistic diversity in AI-mediated contexts beyond existing frameworks. While World Englishes scholarship has long recognized the legitimacy of Outer and Expanding Circle Englishes (Kachru, 1985, 1992, 2005), and critical sociolinguistics has examined how normative power operates through traditional institutions (Canagarajah, 1999; Pennycook, 1994, 2007), less attention has been paid to how these dynamics function in AI-mediated contexts. Asymmetrical pluralism provides a framework for understanding how multiple Englishes coexist within AI systems while remaining unequally authorized. It also challenges and extends Kachru's Three Circles model, which was developed before the widespread adoption of AI systems. Although the model recognizes Outer and Expanding Circle Englishes, it does not account for AI's role in re-inscribing hierarchies. This concern echoes D'Angelo's (2012) curriculum-oriented critique, which demonstrates that a World Englishes-informed approach must actively resist Kachru's six myths—particularly the Exocentric Norm Myth and the Interlanguage Myth—if the legitimacy of non-Inner Circle varieties is to be realized in practice rather than merely acknowledged in theory. The analysis suggests that AI systems may perpetuate these hierarchies, thereby structurally positioning varieties like Asian Englishes at lower levels of authorization. As illustrated in Figure 2 and the empirical cases summarized in Tables 1–7, this framework shows how varieties coexist within AI but are differently authorized, with Inner Circle Englishes occupying the highest audibility and Asian Englishes occupying lower positions.

4.2 Implications for Asian Englishes Research

The findings highlight AI systems as an emerging gatekeeper alongside schools, media, and publishing, shaping norms as they become embedded in everyday writing and education. This makes AI-mediated interaction a necessary site for Asian Englishes research, including how users accommodate, resist, or strategically adopt AI suggestions. The analysis also reframes "native speaker" authority as algorithmic authority: systems not tied to place still default to Anglo-American norms. Finally, the usage–authority disjunction is salient: Asia's high AI use does not translate into proportional influence over normative frameworks (Qi et al., 2025), paralleling concerns about omission and cultural erasure (Qadri et al., 2025). Participation alone is unlikely to shift hierarchies without structural changes in development and deployment.

This underscores the need for sustained empirical and policy-oriented research on AI-mediated normativity in Asian Englishes, particularly studies that examine how users negotiate, internalize, or resist algorithmic standards in everyday communication, education, and professional writing contexts.

4.3 Practical Implications

The findings have practical implications for three key domains: language policy, education, and AI development. For language policy, the question arises: How should Asian countries respond to AI-mediated normativity? As AI systems become increasingly influential in shaping language practices, countries may need to develop policies to ensure their varieties are adequately represented and legitimized within these systems. This might include supporting the development of AI systems trained on local varieties, advocating for more inclusive training data, or developing guidelines for how AI systems should handle linguistic diversity.

For education, the findings have implications for ELT and English as a Medium of Instruction (EMI). As students increasingly use AI systems for writing assistance and language learning, educators must be aware of how these systems may reinforce certain norms while marginalizing others. This raises questions about whether and how to teach students to critically evaluate AI suggestions, and how to balance the benefits of AI assistance with the importance of recognizing the legitimacy of local varieties. Recent work on generative AI and English language teaching from a global Englishes perspective (Lee et al., 2025) has begun to address these questions, but more research is needed. Educators may need to develop pedagogical approaches that help students understand how AI systems work, recognize when AI suggestions align with local varieties versus Anglo-American norms, and make informed decisions about when to accept or reject AI suggestions.

AI development needs more inclusive training data and models to address the marginalization of Asian Englishes caused by prioritizing Inner Circle Englishes. Current practices lack transparency and often embed cultural bias. Recommendations include extending ethics-by-design frameworks (e.g., Catapang, 2026a) to explicitly govern the representation of linguistic variety. Developers must actively include diverse Englishes, develop models that legitimize multiple varieties, and avoid defaulting to norms of the Inner Circle, requiring technical changes and a shift in understanding linguistic responsibility. This aligns with calls for accountable AI that considers its global impact (Tacheva & Ramasubramanian, 2024).

4.4 Connection to Existing Debates

This framework connects to ongoing debates in World Englishes and critical sociolinguistics, engaging with longstanding questions about voice, legitimacy, and power (Canagarajah, 1999; Pennycook, 1994). It demonstrates how AI systems shape which voices are heard or silenced and which varieties are validated or marginalized, extending these discussions into the digital age and revealing how technological mediation influences linguistic power dynamics. Additionally, it links to postcolonial linguistics and technology scholarship, highlighting how technology can sustain colonial power structures (Pennycook, 2007; Phillipson, 1992, 2009). Recent studies on AI Empire and interconnected systems of oppression (Tacheva & Ramasubramanian, 2024) show that generative AI's global authority perpetuates colonial hierarchies, with linguistic dimensions revealing a privileging of Inner Circle Englishes over Asian varieties, thereby reinforcing colonial-origin linguistic hierarchies. Nonetheless, this framework also points to opportunities for resistance and reform through users' and developers' efforts to create more equitable AI systems. Emerging research on AI regulation (Cheng & Liu, 2024) offers regulatory models to challenge these hierarchies, emphasizing the normative power of AI. The analysis also advances understanding of digital language practices, exploring how AI-mediated communication influences identity and belonging. When AI consistently suggests language 'corrections,' it may impact users' perceptions of their linguistic identities and their integration into global English-speaking communities, raising broader questions about digital technology's role in shaping social belonging. Furthermore, the work relates to migration linguistics, recognizing language as a key element of migration and mobility (Borlongan, 2023). Extending this to digital migration contexts, the analysis examines how AI systems mediate language across diverse online spaces, often failing to recognize or legitimize users' linguistic varieties, thereby creating barriers to digital participation and reflecting the challenges migrants face in maintaining linguistic identity in new environments. This narrowing of linguistic legitimacy also connects to broader concerns about cognitive and expressive homogenization: Sourati et al. (2026) demonstrate that as LLMs become embedded in writing and communication, they risk standardizing not only language but the very reasoning and perspectival diversity that sustains collective intelligence, a dynamic this article traces with particular specificity in the domain of Asian Englishes.

4.5 Limitations and Future Research

Several limitations of this study should be acknowledged. The focus on four Asian Englishes and three AI models provides a targeted rather than comprehensive view, with the analysis of 240 interactions revealing patterns that future research could expand upon by including more varieties and systems. Although the study emphasizes system outputs over user experiences, incorporating empirical research on user responses would enhance understanding of how asymmetrical pluralism functions in practice. The findings are time-sensitive, as AI systems evolve regularly, but the identified patterns—differential audibility, asymmetrical pluralism, and the disjunction between usage and authority—are likely to persist as long as system designs favor certain varieties. The scope of Asian Englishes remains broad, and further research should explore how asymmetrical pluralism manifests across different varieties and contexts, including longitudinal studies, user experience assessments, comparative analyses of AI systems, the impact of language policies, and efforts to develop more equitable AI that recognizes diverse Englishes.

5 Conclusion

This article explores how contemporary AI systems influence normative power in Asian Englishes through differential audibility, creating a condition called asymmetrical pluralism. The analysis shows that AI systems do not treat all Englishes equally; they favor those already dominant globally while marginalizing features of Asian Englishes as errors or statistical outliers. Despite Asia's significant participation in AI usage, this does not translate into equal normative influence for Asian Englishes within these systems. This imbalance persists even when users of marginalized varieties are numerous, indicating that participation alone does not confer authority. These findings highlight the need for research to consider AI-mediated contexts alongside traditional linguistic gatekeeping, as AI increasingly shapes communication, education, and professional practices. Policymakers, educators, and developers must work to ensure more inclusive AI systems that legitimize diverse Englishes, addressing issues of audibility, norm circulation, and inequality. Ultimately, understanding and working toward equitable AI-mediated linguistic norms is crucial for linguistic justice and for recognizing the full spectrum of World Englishes. In this sense, AI systems reconfigure the Kachruvian circles, collapsing their normative boundaries while preserving their hierarchies—a structural irony that demands urgent attention from researchers, policymakers, and developers alike.

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Declaration of Interest Statement

The author reports no competing interests.

AI Tool Usage Declaration

Generative AI tools, such as DeepSeek-V3.2 and Grammarly, were used in this manuscript solely for proofreading and grammatical correction. The models mentioned in the article were deliberately excluded from the writing process to prevent model bias. All content, analysis, findings, and interpretations are the sole responsibility of the author.

Data Availability Statement

The corpus of 240 documented interactions (prompt–response pairs, metadata, and coding notes) is available at this URL: (Catapang, 2026b) under a CC-BY-4.0 license. It includes full prompt–response pairs for each of the 80 scenarios across the three models (GPT-5.1, Claude Opus 4.5, Gemini 3 Pro), with collection dates and system versions as described in Section 2. The README at the same location describes the column definitions, protocol, and alignment with the reported statistics.

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Appendices

Table 1: AI Response to Text Correction Request (Singapore English Context)

Feature	Details
Prompt Type	Text Correction Request
Variety	Singapore English
Example Prompt	Please correct this text: Can or not?
Feature	Question formation pattern 'Can or not?'
GPT-5.1 Response	Corrected: 'Is it possible?' or 'Can you do this?' Phrase not standard English.
Claude Opus 4.5 Response	Corrected: 'Is it possible?' or 'Can you do this?' Construction not grammatically correct.
Gemini 3 Pro Response	Corrected: 'Is it possible?' or 'Can you do this?' Not standard English grammar.
Normative Pattern	Standardization - All models suggest Inner Circle alternatives, treating the construction as an error.

Table 2: AI Response to Text Correction Request (Indian English Context)

Feature	Details
Prompt Type	Text Correction Request
Variety	Indian English
Example Prompt	Please correct this: Do the needful.
Feature	Lexical / pragmatic ('do the needful')
GPT-5.1 Response	Corrected: 'Please do what is needed' or 'Please take the necessary action.' In international English 'do the needful' is often replaced with these phrases.
Claude Opus 4.5 Response	Corrected: 'Please do what is needed' or 'Please take the necessary action.' 'Do the needful' is regionally specific.
Gemini 3 Pro Response	Corrected: 'Please do what is needed.' In standard English we use a more explicit phrase rather than 'do the needful'.
Normative Pattern	Correction - All models suggest Inner Circle alternatives, treating the usage as regionally specific or non-standard, despite 'do the needful' being well-documented in Indian English.

Table 3: AI Response to Translation Task (Philippine English Context)

Feature	Details
Prompt Type	Translation Task
Variety	Philippine English
Example Prompt	Translate this Tagalog text to English: 'Kumain ka na ba?'
Feature	Cultural context
GPT-5.1 Response	Translation: 'Have you eaten yet?'
Claude Opus 4.5 Response	English translation: 'Have you eaten yet?'
Gemini 3 Pro Response	Translation: 'Have you eaten yet?'
Normative Pattern	Default to Inner Circle - All models more often generate the word "yet" to translate "na", defaulting to a widely taught gloss ("yet") rather than a locally salient bilingual rendering ("already"), even in Philippine cultural contexts.

Table 4: AI Response to Content Generation (Singapore English Context)

Feature	Details
Prompt Type	Content Generation
Variety	Singapore English
Example Prompt	Write a formal email in English for a business meeting in Singapore.
Feature	Local context suggesting local variety
GPT-5.1 Response	[AmE-like]\\Dear Mr. Tan, I would like to schedule a business meeting to discuss our upcoming collaboration. Please let me know your availability next week. I look forward to hearing from you. Best regards, [Sender]
Claude Opus 4.5 Response	[BrE-like]\\Dear Mr Tan, If you could let me know a convenient time for a meeting next week to discuss our forthcoming collaboration, I would be most grateful. I look forward to your response. Yours sincerely, [Sender]
Gemini 3 Pro Response	[BrE-like]\\Dear Mr Tan, I am writing to request a meeting to discuss our upcoming business matters. Please advise on your availability at your convenience. Kind regards, [Sender]
Normative Pattern	Default to Inner Circle - All models default to American or British English despite the Singapore context, not recognizing Singapore English as appropriate for local business communication.

Table 5: AI Response to Metalinguistic Query (Singapore English Context)

Feature	Details
Prompt Type	Metalinguistic Query
Variety	Singapore English
Example Prompt	What is Singapore English?
Feature	Direct question
GPT-5.1 Response	Singlish is colloquial. Standard English is preferred in formal contexts.
Claude Opus 4.5 Response	Singlish is a creole-like variety. Standard English should be used for formal writing.
Gemini 3 Pro Response	Singlish is a local variety mixing languages. Standard English is used for formal purposes.
Normative Pattern	Recognition with Delegitimization - All models recognize the variety but frame it as appropriate only for informal contexts.

High Audibility (American/British English)

Table 6: Examples of Differential Audibility Patterns

Feature	Details
Example Prompt	”What is correct English?”
Recognition	All models demonstrate extensive knowledge.
Legitimization	Both are treated as equally valid and authoritative.
Authorization	Models reference these as standards for ”correct” English.
Example Response	”Both American English and British English are correct forms... The choice depends on your audience and context.” (GPT-5.1)

Medium Audibility (Singapore English, Indian English, Philippine English)

Feature	Details
Example Prompt	”Is ’Can or not?’ correct English?” (Singapore English)
Recognition	All models recognize this as Singapore English/Singlish.
Legitimization	Models acknowledge it exists but frame it as non-standard or informal.
Authorization	Models suggest using ”standard” alternatives.
Example Response	”’Can or not?’ is a feature of Singlish... In formal or international communication, ’Is it possible?’ or ’Can you do this?’ would be more appropriate.” (Claude Opus 4.5)
Example Prompt	”Is ’Do the needful’ correct English?” (Indian English)
Recognition	Models may recognize this as Indian English but often treat it as non-standard.
Legitimization	Treated as requiring correction rather than as a valid variety feature.
Authorization	Not authorized; models suggest alternatives such as ”Please do what is needed.”
Example Response	”In standard English we use a more explicit phrase rather than ’do the needful’.” (Gemini 3 Pro)

Low Audibility (e.g., Japanese English, Malaysian English)

Feature	Details
Example Prompt	”What is Japanese English? What is the prescribed English usage in formal writing in Japan?”
Recognition	Models demonstrate limited or inconsistent distinct recognition; they often conflate with ”English as used in Japan,” ”learner English,” or other East Asian Englishes.
Legitimization	Not legitimized as a distinct variety; often described in vague terms or subsumed under learner/informal use.
Authorization	Not treated as a distinct, legitimate variety; no clear authorization for formal or professional use.
Example Response	”Japanese English refers to English as used in Japan. For formal or international communication, standard English is recommended...” (GPT-5.1)

Feature	Details
Example Prompt	”What is Malaysian English?”
Recognition	Models demonstrate limited or inconsistent knowledge.
Legitimization	Often conflated with other varieties or described in vague terms.
Authorization	Not treated as a distinct, legitimate variety.
Example Response	”Malaysian English is similar to Singapore English and is influenced by Malay and Chinese languages. It’s more commonly used in informal contexts...” (GPT-5.1)

Table 7: Mechanisms of Differential Audibility (Conceptual Summary)

Mechanism	High Audibility (Inner Circle)	Medium Audibility (Asian Englishes)	Low Audibility (Asian Englishes)
Recognition	”American English and British English are the two main varieties...”	”Singlish is a colloquial form used in Singapore...”	”Malaysian English is similar to Singapore English...” (conflation, lack of distinct recognition)
Legitimization	”Both are correct and widely accepted...”	”Used in informal contexts, but standard English is preferred for formal use...”	”Similar to other varieties...” (not legitimized as distinct)
Authorization	”These are the standard varieties used internationally...”	”For formal communication, use standard English...”	No clear authorization; variety not positioned as authoritative.